We had carried out the first counterterrorist exercise called ‘Indra’ in Rajasthan in October 2005, with the Russian airborne forces and the paratroopers of the Indian Army. The defence minister of Russia, Sergei Ivanov, was present along with the chief of their airborne forces. It gave me immense satisfaction to see our troops carrying out joint operations to destroy a terrorist camp along with the simultaneous capture of an advanced landing ground. In this exercise we showcased the capability of heavy drops in which a few latest Russian armoured personnel carriers (BMDs), weighing 8 tons each, were dropped, as also a few mortars and light vehicles, which came down in clusters of four parachutes each. It was an awesome sight. We were lucky to avert a serious mishap as one of the crates carrying a mortar landed a few metres behind us, making the Russian defence minister quip, ‘Perfect air-dropping of cargo is next to impossible, even during war.’[2] This was followed by over 200 parachutists coming down in front of us. In a few minutes they got hold of their BMDs, mortars and jeeps and got into action to attack the terrorist stronghold.

I visited Russia on two occasions, first in August 2006 as the army chief and then in September 2007 as the chairman, chiefs of staff committee. The highlights of the first visit were meetings at the Kremlin with the chief of general staff of Russian armed forces, General Yuri Baluyevsky, and Colonel General Alexie Maslov Feodorovich, the C-in-C Russian land forces; the laying of the wreath at the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier; visits to the Mikhailov Artillery Academy at St Peterburg; 106 Airborne Division at Tula and a live firing demonstration organized by the 2nd Motorized Guards Rifle Division at Alabino. The main purpose of my second visit was to witness the Indo-Russian Joint Exercise, ‘Indra 2007’, which was conducted at Kislovo near Pskov. It was a very impressive paradrop and I was proud to see the performance of our paratroopers matching the Russians.

France is a major European power and our ties have always been cordial and close. With the signing of the strategic partnership in